

THE OLD DUKE'S WARS

Vignettes from the Life of DUKE BRAEDON
FENWOOD

THE GRAY WANDERER

Set down from the deathbed ledger

Tarlington, winter of 908 AR

Under the lamp, bread and salt.
The ink is blood and lamp-black.

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Colophon**35**

A NOTE ON THIS WRITING

THIS ledger was found pressed between the leaves of a Canray slate, on the table beside Duke Braedon Fenwood's deathbed. The ink is his own blood—the last move of a game he could not finish. The pages are foxed, some stained by wine, others by tears. A single braid of Ykrul horsehair marks the place where the old man stopped writing.

THE GRAY WANDERER has added marginal notes in a drier hand. Where the duke's memory falters, we have bracketed the uncertainty. Where the truth is too cruel for ink, we have left a space.

This is not a chronicle of triumph. It is a record of what a house must bury to survive. And it ends where the next ledger begins—on the river Belworth, with blood in the water and a crown still warm.

The Deathbed Ledger

This document serves as both narrative and **campaign frame**. The vignettes recount DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD's life, but they also establish **Strings**, **Obligations**, and **Assets** for characters in the Fenwood

bloodline.

Required: *The Exile Road*, *The Reckoning Bridge*, and the **Kon'reh** rules.

— *The Archive of the True Masons*, Tarlington chapter, winter of 908 AR

CHAPTER 1

FRAME: THE SOLAR AT TARLINGTON

The fire burns low. Outside, the Belworth churns with winter melt. DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD lies propped on pillows. A Canray slate rests on his chest. The pieces are not set.

THE GRAY WANDERER

THE old duke is dying. His left arm is dead—eight years cold since the Sack of Lence—and his breath comes in shallow tides. But his eyes are clear, and his voice, when he speaks, carries the weight of sixty-six years of ledger-keeping.

You have been summoned to his solar. Not as servants. As witnesses. As the ones who must remember when he is ash.

“Sit,” he says. *“I will not rise again. But I will speak. The*

2 CHAPTER 1. FRAME: THE SOLAR AT TARLINGTON

road does not forgive a debt. It only reschedules it. You are the ledger now.”

He tells you seven stories. They are not in order. They are not kind. They are his confession, his instruction, and his final game of Canray—played with blood instead of wine.

Frame Mechanics: The Seven Vignettes

Each vignette represents a **memory** that DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD bequeaths. After each story, the players may ask one question. If they succeed on a **Wits + Insight** roll (**DV 3**), they gain a **String** on the subject of the vignette (e.g., “*The Oath of the Yloka*” or “*The Spared Thornhill*”).

When DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD dies (at the end of the seventh vignette), any unspent Strings become **Obligations** owed by his heirs.

CHAPTER 2

THE BLACK BANNER YEARS (AGE TWENTY-TWO)

I was a second son. My brother Conlin was the heir—clever, careful, born with a club foot that our father called a curse and I called an excuse.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

I had no land, no title, no purpose. So I ran.

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD ran with me. He was also a second son—King Harald IV’s second boy, not the heir. Harald the Bold was the elder; KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD and I squired together under Oswin Everblood. We sharpened each other’s blades and lied about each other’s conquests. When I said, “*I’m leaving*,” he said, “*I’ll bring the horses*.”

We joined the Black Banners—the ones who fought the Ykrul raiders in the steppe passes. Our captain was

4CHAPTER 2. THE BLACK BANNER YEARS (AGE TWENTY-TWO)

a woman called SØREN THE ONE-EYED, Linnic, scarred, and patient as frost. She taught us the first rule of war: *“Count exits, not victims. The road remembers.”*

THE FIRST BLOOD

Our first skirmish was a ford crossing. I was seventeen and terrified. KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD was eighteen and pretending not to be. The Ykrul came out of the mist with wolf-tail standards. I killed a man—a boy, really—with a spear through the throat. He looked at me as if I had stolen something.

I did. I stole his tomorrows.

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD pulled me up. *“Don’t name him,”* he said. *“Names are anchors. You’ll carry him forever if you speak it.”*

I did not speak it. I still see his face.

THE WITCH’S CLOSING.

The first debt is always blood. It cannot be paid, only carried. The Black Banners do not keep ledgers of the dead; they keep braids of the living—to remind themselves who still owes the road a death.

THE BOND

Captain SØREN THE ONE-EYED matched us in the Kon’reh board. She played with stones, not pieces—river-smooth, each one a different shade of gray. *“Play the player,”* she said, *“not the position.”* KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD beat

me three times. I beat him twice. We never kept score. Friendship is not a ledger.

Later, in a camp by the Yloka, we swore an oath. Not on a book—on a braid of horsehair cut from the mane of a fallen Ykrul mare.

“If one of us becomes king, the other will be his hand. If one of us dies, the other will avenge him. If we both die, the road will remember.”

He became king. I became his hand. I also married his sister, Aobrey. The road remembers.

Asset: The Oath of the Yloka

If the party includes a Fenwood heir, they may invoke this oath once per campaign. When a Everblood is in danger, they may declare: *“The Yloka remembers.”* Gain *+2dice* to any roll to save or avenge an Everblood, but mark *Obligation 2* to the Ykrul.

THE RETURN

My brother Conlin died of a fever. I inherited the duchy. I came home to Tarlington with a Ykrul braid in my pocket, a Kon’reh board in my saddlebag, and Aobrey on a pillion behind me. My father met us at the gate.

“You smell of the steppe,” he said. Then he kissed my bride’s hand. *“Good. Stinks of honest work.”*

Thus endeth the first vignette. The fire cracks. DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD drinks watered wine. His hand does not tremble yet.

6 *CHAPTER 2. THE BLACK BANNER YEARS (AGE TWENTY-TWO)*

CHAPTER 3

THE THORNHILL REBELLION (AGE THIRTY-SIX)

The rape of Alayse Everblood—KING BALDVYN
EVERBLOOD's youngest sister—was not a secret.
Branton Thornhill made it a boast.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

THE rape of Alayse Everblood was not a secret. Branton Thornhill made it a boast. He sent the king a lock of her hair wrapped in a marriage contract. *"She came willingly,"* he wrote. *"Your sister is a whore, and I am her lord."*

King Harald IV rode to Brigh. He never came back. They killed him in a ditch, his own sword in his belly.

Then Harald the Bold—the elder brother, the heir—stormed the same walls. An arrow took his eye eleven

days later. He lingered. He did not recover.

They crowned KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD in a field, with a borrowed coronet and a dead brother's blood on his hands.

THE SIEGE OF BRIGH

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD summoned his banners. I brought eight hundred Fenwood spears—every man who could hold a pike, every woman who could ride. We encamped in the shadow of Branton's keep. The walls were high. The garrison was hungry. Branton mocked us from the parapet.

"Fenwood," he called down. "You were a mercenary. How much did they pay you to betray your people?"

I did not answer. KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD looked at me. "He wants rage. Give him geometry."

I spent the night tracing the keep's drainage sluice. By dawn, we had a tunnel. By noon, we were inside.

Tactical Lesson: The Geometry of Rage

DUKE

BRAEDON FENWOOD teaches: *Rage is a weapon that wounds the wielder.* In combat, any PC who acts from *Rage* gains

+1Harm on their attacks but suffers *-1Position* on defense. The **Geometry** approach *+1die* to any roll that exploits terrain or supply lines instead of frontal assault.

THE DUEL

Branton met KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD in the great hall. The fire was out. The tapestries had been cut down for

bandages. They fought with longswords—no shields, no quarter. I held the door against Branton’s guard.

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD was faster. Branton was stronger. It ended when KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD caught Branton’s blade on his gorget, shattered the steel, and drove his own sword through the lord’s chest.

“For Alayse,” he said. *“For Harald. For my brother.”* He twisted the blade. Branton died with a smile.

THE CHILD

A servant woman fled the keep carrying a boy—Logan Thornhill, Branton’s son, perhaps four years old. KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD drew his dagger. I caught his wrist.

“He is a child.”

“He is a seed.”

“Then prune him gently, or the root will spread.”

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD lowered the blade. He exiled the boy. The woman took him to Vhasia. Years later, that boy would kill Lyonel Vayle’s father, and QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD would hunt him to a village called Coldmorrow, and she would burn it to ash.

“Mercy,” KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD said later, *“is a debt. You just rescheduled it.”*

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD sets down his cup. His hand trembles. The fire has burned low.

THE WITCH’S CLOSING.

Mercy is the most expensive debt. It accrues interest not in gold, but in blood. The spared child grows

10 CHAPTER 3. THE THORNHILL REBELLION (AGE THIRTY-SIX)

to manhood, and the man remembers who held the blade that did not fall. This is why the Daughters of the Cord teach: Kill cleanly, or adopt fully. There is no middle ground.

CHAPTER 4

THE LONGBLOOD DEFIANCE (AGE FORTY-EIGHT)

Elianor of Adria was a warrior queen. She had fought beside KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD, borne him children, ruled the marches when the king was away at war. But KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD grew tired.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

ELIANOR of Adria was a warrior queen. She had fought beside KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD, borne him children, ruled the marches when the king was away at war. But KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD grew tired. He took lovers—men and women both, openly, cruelly. Elianor's pride curdled into rebellion.

She raised the banners of Adria, Ethor, and the Bloods

of Lence. Her son Valdaïs—or perhaps her brother? the lineage was tangled—rode at her side. KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD called his host. I sat at the council table and watched two people I loved prepare to murder each other.

THE FAILED MEDIATION

I rode to Elianor's camp under a flag of parley. She met me in a tent that smelled of wine and grief.

"You were his friend," she said. "You know what he is."

"I know what he was. He is still my king."

"Then you will die for him."

"I will die for the realm."

She laughed. It was not a kind sound. *"There is no realm. There are only debts and ledgers."*

I rode back. KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD asked me what she said. I told him. He nodded. *"Then let the ledgers speak."*

THE BATTLE OF CHARAU

I commanded the left flank. The ground was wet with autumn rain. The Bloods of Lence charged us three times. Three times we threw them back. Valdaïs—young, arrogant, his mother's fury in his eyes—broke through a gap in the line and rode straight for KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD's standard.

I caught him with a mace. His horse went down. He crawled for his sword. I put my boot on his hand.

"Yield."

He spat at me.

I could have killed him. I should have killed him. But I saw Elianor's face in his. I pulled him up and marched him, stumbling, to KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD.

THE PARDON

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD wanted execution. *"He raised arms against his king."*

"He is your son—or your half-brother. No one is certain. Does it matter?"

"He will rebel again."

"Then let him owe his life to mercy. A debt unpaid is a leash."

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD chewed his rage for a long minute. Then he ordered Valdais confined to his estates. Elianor was exiled to a convent. The war ended.

Valdais never rebelled again. He became a quiet, loyal duke. And when KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD died, Valdais wept.

"Mercy," DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD says, *"is not weakness. It is a long loan."*

The Long Loan

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD's mercy created a **Debt Timer [6]** for Valdais. It never filled. When Valdais wept at KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD's funeral, the timer was paid in full, and the debt was erased.

14 *CHAPTER 4. THE LONGBLOOD DEFIANCE (AGE FORTY-EIGHT)*

This is rare. Most debts of mercy fill their timers and demand payment in the next generation.

CHAPTER 5

THE SACK OF LENCE (AGE SIXTY)

The Vhasian king demanded homage. We had lands in Vhasia—old Valvano holdings, granted by the first Everbloods. We had never paid tribute.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

THE Vhasian king demanded homage. We had lands in Vhasia—old Valvano holdings, granted by the first Everbloods. We had never paid tribute. He sent tax collectors. I sent them back with their papers shredded.

He declared war. I laughed. Then I raised the banners.

THE INVASION

My son Seniro commanded the vanguard. Wymund the Red—hot-headed, boisterous, secretly gentle. He rode with the Everbloods of Aberiel, with Harald and Elyas beside him. Young knights, hungry for glory. QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD was fifteen. She dressed as a page, hid in a supply wagon, presented herself at my tent.

“I will fight.”

“Your father would kill me.”

“My father is not here.”

I assigned her to Seniro as a squire. She watched the streets of Lence run with blood.

THE SIEGE

We broke the walls on the third day. Street fighting—house to house, room to room. I lost my horse to a cross-bow bolt. My left arm went dead. A Vhasian spearman knelt over me, raised his weapon.

Seniro cut him down. *“Stay down, Father.”*

I stayed down. I watched from the mud as Seniro’s men burned the palace.

Condition: The Dead Arm

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD gains the permanent condition *The Dead Arm* from this wound. All **Body** rolls involving two hands suffer

--_{1die}. However, he gains +_{1die} to **Insight** rolls involving patience or suffering. This condition passes to any PC who inherits his mantle.

THE LAST THORNHILL

Logan Thornhill—the boy I had spared—was a man now. He had fought for Vhasia, risen to captain, taken a new name. QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD tracked him to a village called Coldmorrow.

I did not see the killing. I saw the aftermath: smoke rising from a hundred thatched roofs, and QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD standing in the square with a mace dripping gore.

“He insulted my father,” she said. “He killed my cousin.”

“He was a child once.”

“He was a monster grown.”

I did not argue. I took her aside. *“You will carry this weight forever. That is the price of the blade. Do not let it crush you. Let it make you sharp.”*

She wept. I held her. We did not speak of it again.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD touches his dead arm. “The boy I spared killed the man I should have been.”

THE WITCH’S CLOSING.

The spared enemy is a debt that always comes due. They do not forget the mercy, but they misremember it as weakness. When they return, they come not as grateful sons but as creditors, demanding payment in the coin of vengeance.

CHAPTER 6

THE DYING KING (AGE SIXTY-FOUR)

Baldvyn called me to his bedside. He was wasted,
yellowed, his breath sour with the canker that
had eaten his stomach.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

BALDVYN called me to his bedside. He was wasted,
yellowed, his breath sour with the canker that had
eaten his stomach. The physicians had bled him white.
Nothing helped.

"I am dying," he said.

"You are old."

"I am sixty-four."

"So am I."

He laughed, then coughed blood. *"Remember the
Yloka? The ford?"*

"I remember."

"You saved my life."

"You saved mine first."

He pressed a letter into my hand. *"Open it when I am gone. Not before."*

THE TOURNAMENT

KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD died a week later. His son Wyllmot—the Warrior, the Pious, the Brute—planned a grand tournament to honor the succession. QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD asked to compete. Wyllmot refused. She rode anyway.

She unhorsed three knights: Arin Tymber, my son Lerris, and Ouen Longblood. Ouen's horse died under him. He called her a whore. She dismounted and broke his jaw.

Tylan Vayle—quiet, patient, a wall of muscle—defeated her in the quarterfinal. He did not gloat. He offered her his hand. *"You fought well, cousin."*

She took it. She smiled for the first time in months.

THE LETTER

I opened KING BALDVYN EVERBLOOD's letter after the tourney. It said only this:

"Watch over Wyllmot. He has my rage without my restraint. Watch over Veralyn. She has my mother's fire, and it will burn her if no one holds the bucket. You were

my brother in all but blood. Do not let my blood destroy your name.”

I burned the letter. The oath remains.

“Wyllmot,” DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD says, “was a brute. But he was my king. I kept my oath.”

The Unburned Oath

Although DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD burned the letter, the **Oath to Baldvyn** remains as a *Persistent Debt*. Any Fenwood heir who fails to protect an Everblood from harm suffers

--_{1die} *to all social rolls involving loyalty or honor until they perform penance.* This debt cannot be paid off. It can only be passed to the next generation.

CHAPTER 7

THE SEVEN WEEK UPRISING (AGE SIXTY-FIVE)

Myrmis worshippers rose in the mountains. They
killed lords, burned synods, declared a holy war
against the Unity of Light.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

MYRMIS worshippers rose in the mountains. They
killed lords, burned synods, declared a holy war
against the Unity of Light. Wyllmot marched to storm
their citadel—Eryas, a fortress carved into a cliff.

I counseled patience. *“Let them starve. Winter is
coming.”*

Wyllmot heard nothing. *“They killed my cousin. They
defiled a temple. I will have blood.”*

He led the assault himself. A rockslide caught the

vanguard. Wyllmot died with a spear through his chest, still swinging his axe.

THE SUCCESSION

Baldvyn Brightstride—Wyllmot's son, young, untested—sat the throne. QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD rode for the mountains. I stayed in Tarlington with a garrison of old men and wounded.

"You are not a warrior anymore," my son Constano said.

"I am a duke. I am a strategist. I am a man who has buried too many friends."

THE CONSPIRACY

We learned later that Alaysha Renard—Wyllmot's widow, QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD's mother—had prayed to Myrmis on the eve of her wedding. She had sacrificed her favorite hound for three daughters and two sons. The goddess granted her wish—then demanded payment.

Alaysha had not paid. The goddess took Wyllmot.

I warned QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD: *"Trust your mother not at all. She serves a god that demands sacrifice."*

QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD said nothing. She had already known.

"Some debts," DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD says, *"are not rescheduled. They are inherited."*

THE WITCH'S CLOSING.

Gods are the ultimate creditors. They do not accept gold. They accept only what is precious—hounds, children, kings. Myrmis is patient. She will wait a generation for her payment. And when it comes due, it will be with interest.

CHAPTER 8

THE DEATH OF BRIGHTSTRIDE (TWO WEEKS AGO – AGE SIXTY-SIX)

Baldvyn Brightstride was young, handsome, beloved. He had been married three months—to my granddaughter, Jaennis.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD

BALDVYN Brightstride was young, handsome, beloved. He had the charm of his father and the restraint of his grandmother. He had been married three months—to my granddaughter, Jaennis, a waif of a girl with chestnut hair and silent eyes.

He complained of a chill. He drank a posset. He died before dawn.

The physicians said fever. I said poison.

THE SUSPECTS

The Renards had motive. The Longbloods had opportunity. The Vhasian Regency—still nursing the wounds of Lence—had means.

Jaennis wept at the funeral. I watched her. She did not weep for a husband. She wept for a future stolen.

“Did you kill him?” I asked her later.

“I am a Fenwood. I do not answer that question.”

“Answer it.”

“He was kind. He was gentle. He did not deserve the crown.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one I have.”

THE SUCCESSION CRISIS

QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD is the named heir. But Valdais—Elianor’s son, my spared captive—presses his claim. Aleric, Alaysha’s nephew, whispers in dark corners. The realm teeters.

I have written QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD a letter. *“Take the crown. Hold it. Let no one tell you that you are not worthy. You are a Fenwood. We are made of exile and iron.”*

I have not sent it. I will send it with you.

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD hands a sealed parchment to

the senior PC. “Deliver this. Then come back. The river is rising. The next war begins at dawn.”

The Succession Crisis Timers

As

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD dies, the following timers begin:

Valdais’s Claim [6]: Advances when his legitimacy is discussed. When full, he marches on the capital.

Veralyn’s Coronation [4]: Advances when her claim is supported. When full, she is crowned—but the realm is divided.

The Poison Investigation [8]: Advances when clues are found. When full, the killer is revealed (Jaennis, Alaysha, or Vhasian agents—GM’s choice).

CHAPTER 9

EPILOGUE: THE ROAD RESCHEDULES

THE fire is ash. DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD lies still. His chest rises once, twice—then stops.

A servant draws the sheet over his face. The Canray slate falls from his hand. The pieces scatter.

One—a Blue—comes to rest against the hearth. The rest are lost in shadow.

THE GRAY WANDERER picks up the slate. The unfinished game is a puzzle. *“He was playing for time. He always played for time.”*

Outside, the Belworth churns. Riders are crossing. The road does not forgive a debt. It only reschedules.

— *To be continued in “Blood on the Belworth.”*

APPENDIX: THE CANRAY BOARD & MECHANICAL INTEGRATION

THE UNFINISHED GAME

DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD's Canray slate represents the **Succession Crisis**. The GM should use actual Kon'reh pieces or a diagram:

Piece	Significance
Blue (Throne)	Isolated, with few supporting pieces—QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD's precarious position.
Oranges (Allies)	Two forks: one aligned with Blue, one distant—the divided Viterran/Vhasian courts.
Reds (Fenwood)	Defensive wall along the home rank, with a single gap (the Belworth crossing).
Green (Runner)	Locked behind enemy lines—the message DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD wants delivered.

The Solution: Sacrifice the Blue to free the Green. A metaphor for DUKE BRAEDON FENWOOD dying so QUEEN VERALYN EVERBLOOD can escape the board (the throne) and live.

INHERITABLE CONDITIONS

Any PC who is a Fenwood heir may inherit:

- *The Dead Arm:* -1 die to two-handed Body rolls; +1 die to patience-based Insight rolls.
- *The Oath of the Yloka:* Once per campaign, +2 dice to save an Everblood; Obligation 2 to Gray Ash.
- *The Spared Thornhill:* Logan Thornhill's descendants (if any survived Coldmorrow) have a String on you.

COLOPHON

THIS book was written in the solar at Tarlington, on paper that had once been a grain manifest. The ink is lamp-black cut with the ash of a burned confession. The binding is horsehair, tied with nine knots.

The ninth knot is not cut.

The old duke is dead. The road is still south. The river rises.

— *THE GRAY WANDERER, at the edge of the Belworth, dawn of the Crisis.*